

Chapter 11

Introducing, Conducting, and Processing Exercises

For exercises to be productive and useful, they must be introduced properly, conducted properly, and processed in a way that is helpful for the members. In this chapter, we address each of these important skills.

Introducing an Exercise

Proper introduction of an exercise means giving clear instructions to members on how to carry out the exercise. This is as important as the exercise itself. Leaders often give ample thought to the exercise, but if their instructions are not clearly presented and if certain cautions are not expressed, the likely result will be confusion, and the exercise will be almost meaningless.

During the introduction of an exercise, it is important to set the right tone. To accomplish this, the leader should pay careful attention to the use of his voice. If the exercise is to be a serious or thought-provoking one, the leader will want to slow down his delivery, using pauses and a quieter voice. If it is to be an energizing, fun exercise, the leader would want to speed up the delivery, using a very enthusiastic voice. Too often, leaders fail to use their voices effectively, and the exercise does not produce the desired kinds of responses.

When introducing an exercise, it is also important to gain the cooperation of the members. Therefore, members should not be made to feel the leader is doing something to them or that they are being forced to participate. *It should be made clear that members have the right not to participate if they so desire.* There is greater

likelihood that the exercise will be beneficial if the members are participating of their own free will.

General Considerations

Inform Members of the Purpose and Procedure When introducing most exercises, the leader will want to inform the members of the purpose and how the exercise will be conducted. A straightforward introduction allows members to have more understanding of the exercise and increases cooperation.

EXAMPLES

Effective Introduction

LEADER: Today I am going to show you some pictures I cut out of a magazine. I am going to ask you to make up a story about one scene. One purpose of this exercise is to help you realize that each of us has our own way of seeing things. There are no right or wrong answers, and I think you will find this really interesting.

In this example, the leader hopes to relieve any uncomfortable feelings that members might have about sharing their stories. In the following example, the leader is less effective because she does not tell the members why they are being asked to make up stories about the various pictures.

Ineffective Introduction

LEADER: I want you to look at the picture and tell me what you see. Who wants to go first?

In some exercises it is not desirable to inform the members fully of the purpose, because telling them could interfere with the effect. When introducing such exercises, it is a good idea to tell the members that the purpose will be explained following the exercise. Again, the leader's attitude as reflected in tone of voice, gestures, and related cues will be a major factor in ensuring cooperation.

Avoid Confusing Directions If the instructions on how to complete the exercise are not clearly presented, members become confused and do not fully participate. The leader must make sure all members understand the directions. The directions should be as simple as possible. If the exercise is a complex one where members are going to be asked to do a number of

things, we suggest that leaders practice giving the directions to colleagues or friends before doing so in the group. In the following ineffective example, the leader would have seen that the directions were too vague had he practiced them with someone first.

EXAMPLES

Ineffective Introduction

LEADER: Each of you will receive an envelope that has a task described in it and some materials. You are to try to complete the task without talking to others. The tasks are different. The goal is to try to finish before anyone else.

The exercise involves members cooperating with each other; they may actually share materials and work together to complete the task, but the leader fails to point this out. By failing to tell them that they may share, this leader causes some members to become frustrated and think that materials were omitted from their envelopes or that others were given more items and that the exercise is unfair.

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Effective Introduction

LEADER: Each of you will receive an envelope that has a number of things in it, such as tape, a pencil, or a ruler. Also included is the description of a task to complete. The task will be something such as "Make a 3-inch by 6-inch red rectangle and tape it to a white circle." In order to complete the task, you will need to share with others because your envelope will not include all the materials necessary for completing the task. You can negotiate with other members, but you can do this only nonverbally—that is, no talking. The goal is to try to finish before anyone else.

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When giving directions for an exercise, the leader should be watching members' reactions. Nonverbal cues will often tell her if the members understand the directions. If the directions are not clarified at the beginning, members will interpret how to do the exercise in many different ways, causing the leader to have a difficult time processing it effectively. Also, members find it very frustrating when they do not understand directions.

Another mistake occurs when the leader comments on how the exercise will help the members focus on some topic when, in fact, it does not do so. Members focus in one direction; then, when the leader gives the actual directions, they are confused.

EXAMPLES

Ineffective Introduction

LEADER: Today we are going to focus on how you have fun in your life. I think more thought needs to be given to this topic of fun. I want you to pair up and, with your partner, discuss how you and your family spent weekends, vacations, and summers when you were young.

Here the leader makes two mistakes: The leader implies that the discussion about fun will relate to the present but then focuses the members on the past. Second, the leader assumes that fun takes place only on weekends and vacations. This may be the leader's frame of reference, but she overlooks the fact that people can have fun completing a difficult task, playing with children, cooking dinner, and so forth.

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Effective Introduction

LEADER: ... I want you to pair up with your partner and discuss the different ways you have fun by yourself and with others. Think about during the week and weekends and vacations, all the different ways you have fun.

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Ineffective Introduction

LEADER: In a minute, I'm going to ask you to do an exercise that should get you in touch with your thoughts about the difficulties of having a deaf child. There are many difficulties, and I think this exercise will help you get in touch with them. Get out a sheet of paper and a pencil. *(Pause)* I want you to write down the first things that come to mind when I say these key words: *anger, guilt, failure.*

Again, the leader is operating from his own frame of reference. Of the many difficulties that parents of a deaf child may encounter, feelings of guilt or anger may be one, but others have to do with educational issues, financial problems, babysitting and day care, obtaining public services for their child, handling their own fatigue, and so on. By saying that this exercise will get members in touch with their feelings and then doing an exercise that does not necessarily tap into their feelings, the leader's introduction is confusing to the members.

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Ineffective Introduction

Leader: Today we are going to talk about your family of origin and what life was like in your home. I want you to think of the different feelings you had growing up: how you felt about your mom, dad, and any siblings. Maybe there were other significant people in your life such as a grandparent, neighbor, or teacher. On the paper in front of you, I'd like you to draw a rough sketch of the house you grew up in. You can fill in the area around the house—really, anything you want.

As you can see, the leader switched the focus from feelings about family members to a visualization of the house in which members grew up. The two may be related, but they also may be totally unrelated.

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In each of these examples, the leader gets the members thinking one way and then does an exercise that is only slightly related or not related at all. New leaders make this mistake primarily because they have not thought through the issue sufficiently. For instance, in the third example, the leader apparently jumped to the conclusion that focusing on the houses members grew up in would stimulate them to think of their families. After considering this more thoroughly, the leader would realize that the drawing exercise would probably get members in touch with feelings about themselves or events that occurred rather than with feelings about family members. Obviously, there is a major difference in these two topics. A leader should make sure that the introduction fits the exercise *and* that the exercise is relevant to the topic being discussed.

Avoid Lengthy Directions A common mistake group leaders make when introducing exercises is giving directions that are too long or complex. If the instructions are long or complicated, it may be best to give them in stages. For example, if the leader wants members to form triads and each member to play a certain role for the exercise, he should have them form triads and determine who is playing which role before proceeding to the next stage of the instructions.

■ EXAMPLES

Ineffective Introduction

Leader: I want you to get into threes; one of you will be the mother, one will be the child, and one will be the father who is returning the child from a weekend visit with him. Each of you should be upset about something—the mom can be upset about how the dad is always late in bringing the child back. The child is upset about a number of things—he wanted to stay with the dad longer and wanted to go with his dad next weekend, but the dad had to say no. The dad is upset about not

being able to keep his son longer and because he could not have his son next weekend for a special occasion.

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Effective Introduction

LEADER: I want you to get into threes. *(Pause while they do this)* Now I want you to decide who will be the mother, the dad, and the child. *(Pause—leader checks to make sure everyone is doing this.)* Okay, now all those who are playing Mom, here's the role I want you to play.... All those playing Dad, here's the role I want you to play.... And all those who are playing the child, here's the role....

By presenting the instructions in stages, this leader minimizes the confusion.

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Other Common Errors Leaders sometimes assume that the members are prepared to discuss some magazine article, movie, or task assigned from the last session. Instead, the leader should first ask the members if they have completed the assignment. At times, the leader may want to go ahead with the exercise even if one or two members are not prepared, telling them to observe or participate as best they can. An alternative plan is always needed, however, in case the majority is unprepared.

Failure to tell members how long an exercise will last is another mistake of beginning leaders. Without guidelines concerning time, members may either rush to finish or procrastinate and be halfway through when it is time to stop. Something direct, like "We'll spend 5 minutes on this exercise," is sufficient.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Introducing an Exercise

Go to videos 10.1, 10.2, 10.3, and 10.4 and pay particular attention to how the leader introduces the exercise in each of these segments. You can watch the entire segment or just the introduction of each exercise and how it was conducted. Later you will be encouraged to watch how the exercise was processed.

Exercise-Specific Considerations

Written Exercises When introducing a written exercise, the leader should distribute or ask members to get the necessary materials (usually paper and pencil), let members get settled back into the group, and then give the instructions. If the leader fails to do this and the members have to search for materials, one or more members will forget the instructions.

A leader should always be prepared to provide the necessary writing materials such as pens, pencils, and paper. Even if the leader is certain that members will bring materials with them, it is a good idea to have extra materials on hand in case pencil leads break or ink runs out. When passing out any forms that are going to be completed, it is best to turn them facedown and ask members not to look at them until the instructions have been given completely. Also, the leader should check to see if every member can read and write.

Movement Exercises When introducing movement exercises, it is often best to have members stand and move to the designated starting position before giving the instructions. It is also important that the leader not give the instructions while the members are moving around, because they will not be paying attention.

■ EXAMPLES

Ineffective Introduction

LEADER: We are going to do a movement exercise involving milling. Each of you is to start out in a spot in the room that is far from the center. I am going to ask you to walk around, moving to different parts of the room with your eyes looking downward; then I am going to have you mill around while glancing at each other. Then you will make steady eye contact. Okay, move to a spot that is away from the center. *(Members move to various spots; a couple have to find new spots because another member is there already.)*

JAMES: Now what do we do first? I forgot. Do we glance at each other?

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Effective Introduction

LEADER: We are going to do a movement exercise involving milling. First, I want each of you to find a spot in the room that is far from the center. *(Pauses while members do this)* I want you to look down. *(Checks to see that this is happening)* In a minute, I am going to ask you to mill around while looking down; then I will have you do some additional things. Okay, please start milling around, but continue to keep your heads down.

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Arts and Crafts Exercises Introducing arts and crafts exercises is very similar to introducing written exercises, because materials should be in front of the members before directions are given. Of course, arts and crafts exercises may require many more materials, such as paste, scissors, paint, crayons, and rulers. It is

important to provide the space necessary for members to participate in the exercise in a comfortable manner.

Common Reading Exercises When introducing common readings, the leader may choose to give the instructions before handing out the reading, or he might want to hand out the reading first, facedown. Usually it is a good idea to tell members to mark the sentences or paragraphs that stand out to them as they read—this helps when processing the exercise, because the leader can ask which sentences or paragraphs they marked. Also, the leader may wish to briefly introduce the reading to help the members get a sense of what they will be reading.

Fantasy Exercises When introducing a fantasy exercise, leaders should speak slowly to evoke the feelings and images necessary. It is also important to suggest that members close their eyes during the exercise, but also give them the option to leave their eyes open. Giving members such a choice can help them feel more comfortable with the fantasy exercise. Some leaders make the mistake of closing their eyes. It is important for leaders to keep their eyes open and observe the reactions of the members. Observing the members helps the leader pace the exercise. Also, some members may not be able to get into the fantasy; if the leader observes this, she can anticipate different reactions from those members than from the others.

Feedback Exercises When introducing a feedback exercise, the leader should allow members enough time to think about what they are going to say before they give feedback to other members. The leader will also want to take a minute or two to explain the value of giving helpful feedback. She may want to give examples of what would and would not be helpful. If a leader is not careful in the instructions, the members may give only superficial and meaningless feedback.

Conducting an Exercise

When conducting an exercise, there are at least six considerations of which the leader needs to be aware:

1. Ensuring that members follow instructions
2. Allowing members to not share
3. Handling emotional reactions
4. Changing or stopping the exercise
5. Informing members of the time
6. Deciding whether the leader will participate

Ensuring Members Follow Instructions

Once members begin the exercise, the leader should observe whether they are following through as expected. For example, when members are talking in pairs, they may discuss an issue unrelated to the purpose of the exercise. If the leader observes this, she may move quietly to those members and clarify what they should be doing. If the leader sees that members are laughing or talking when they were instructed not to, the leader will want to intervene, especially when the exercise is meant to be a serious, thought-provoking experience. If a number of members seem confused, the leader may want to go through the instructions again.

Allowing Members to Not Share

In many exercises, such as in rounds or sentence completions, members are asked to respond with a number, a word, or a short answer. The leader needs to be prepared for a member wanting to pass, either because the member feels uncomfortable sharing or because she has not formed a response. When this situation arises, the leader should avoid causing the member discomfort by holding the focus on her. When everyone has commented, the leader may or may not want to bring the focus back to that member. This will depend on how uncomfortable the member seems and the purpose of the group and exercise. Some leaders make the mistake of waiting for a member to respond; this usually causes that member to become more uncomfortable.

■ EXAMPLES

The leader is conducting a round where members describe their early home environment in a word or phrase.

MIKE: Loving, but strict.

MARTY: Good, steady.

ROSA: Can you skip me? I just don't want to say.

LEADER: That's fine. Bill, how about you?

BILL: Happy.

SAM: Good with my mom, hell when Dad was home.

LEADER: Rosa, is it hard to share because it hurts too much?

ROSA: Yes, and I would rather not discuss it right now. Maybe later.

LEADER: Sure. Let's come back to what all of you said. I want you to think about how your upbringing affects you today.

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In the last example, the leader allows the member to not participate in the dyad with another member, but he ends up in a dyad with the reluctant member. Often members will share with a leader but not other members. In this example, the leader has asked members to get into pairs to discuss their feelings about their marriages. The dyads have been in progress for about 45 seconds when one member gets up and walks toward the leader.

PEGGY: I don't feel like talking about this; can I be excused?

LEADER: *(To Peggy's partner)* Dan, why don't you join Jim and Gloria? Peggy, let's talk for a minute so that I know what is going on.

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If a member chooses not to participate at all in an exercise, the leader will want to do everything he can to make that member and the others as comfortable as possible with that decision. Depending on the exercise, the member may sit and observe or leave the room temporarily. If possible, the leader will want to determine why the member does not want to participate and, if appropriate, let the other members know why. In most instances, the leader would not want to take too much time determining the reason if it was going to detract from the exercise. As a rule, unless a member is experiencing a major psychological crisis, it is best not to let one member's needs stop an exercise.

Handling Emotional Reactions

When doing an exercise that focuses members on personal issues, the leader must be prepared for one or more members to react emotionally. Fantasy exercises, feedback exercises, and some movement exercises tend to do this more than others do, but any exercise can stir up intense feelings. If the leader sees that a member is experiencing a strong emotional reaction, she has several options. The option she chooses will depend on the intensity of the situation, the kind of exercise, and the purpose of the group. The leader can stop the exercise and focus on the member; form dyads, pairing up with the member to discuss his or her reaction; or acknowledge the member's discomfort and continue the exercise, allowing the member to listen and learn from the discussion among the other members. If the leader feels the member's reaction is too intense to be handled then, the leader might choose to have the member take a break until the exercise is over or to have another member take a break with that member.

■ EXAMPLES

The group has completed giving feedback to two of five members in the group.

LEADER: Okay, let's move to Kathy next. Look over the list of 25 adjectives and think of those that best describe Kathy.

JOE: Quiet, reserved, caring.

MIGUEL: Quiet, warm, sensitive.

BETTY: Caring, quiet, nice.

LEADER: *(Noticing that Kathy is starting to tear up)* Kathy, would you like to talk about what you are feeling?

KATHY: I don't like it that I am quiet. I wanted so much for someone to say intelligent or strong. All I have ever been seen as is *quiet!* I hate it!

LEADER: Would you like to discuss this some more? *(Kathy nods.)* Okay. Let's talk about how you can change that. Before we start, because our time is limited, I'd like to ask Joe and Yoshe if we can postpone their feedback until next week. *(They nod.)* Kathy, tell us how you would like to be different.

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The group is discussing a sentence-completion form. The questions pertain to attitudes about sex. The sentence they are discussing is "I feel _____ about my early sexual experiences."

LEADER: This question is one that may get you in touch with some guilt or pain. I hope you will be willing to share what you wrote, and perhaps more.

DIANE: I said mostly okay.

DON: Guilty about one thing—good about the rest.

LEADER: Sharon, what did you answer?

SHARON: *(Starting to cry)* I don't want to talk about this right now.

LEADER: Okay, we'll skip you. *(Looking around the group as he talks)* I do want to say that no matter what any of you did, you do not have to feel guilty about it. Hopefully we can focus on how to let go of guilt. Sharon, if it gets too uncomfortable, let me know; otherwise, I hope that you will listen and maybe later join in. Carol, what did you answer?

CAROL: I said that I feel I learned a lot from those early sexual experiences.

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Changing or Stopping the Exercise

When doing an exercise, the leader sometimes decides to change it or to stop. He might do this either because he feels that it is not producing the kinds of responses he had anticipated or because a good topic for discussion has emerged.

■ EXAMPLE

The members of a growth group were asked to list three significant people in their lives. Two of the five members have already shared their lists.

Bobbi: My dad is the most significant person in my life. Last week he went into the hospital with cancer.

Jude: *(Abruptly)* My mom has cancer, too. I didn't put her down as one of my most significant people, but I'm really scared she might die.

Leader: What we might do for a few minutes, if Bobbi and Jude would find it helpful, is to talk about this.

Bobbi: I think it would help me.

Jude: It would definitely help me.

Leader: Okay, let's focus on Bobbi and Jude now, and then we may come back to your lists a little later.

In this example, it seems appropriate to stop the exercise and focus on Bobbi and Jude, who both have immediate needs in common. Illnesses and worry are topics to which most members can relate.

Informing Members of the Time

Leaders should keep members informed about how much time is left to complete the exercise. A statement such as, "Take about 2 more minutes to complete the exercise" is usually a sufficient cue to let members know the amount of time left. Informing members of the time remaining gives them some idea of how to pace themselves to complete the exercise or wind down discussion.

Members are then better prepared to return to the large group to process or discuss material from the exercise. Also, by observing members' reactions to an exercise, the leader may want to lengthen or shorten the amount of time that was originally allotted to it. For instance, if the leader sees that members are actively sharing in their dyads, he may choose to let them continue for a couple of minutes longer than originally planned.

Deciding Whether the Leader Will Participate

Leaders have the option of participating or not participating in an exercise. When deciding whether to participate, leaders should consider the following:

- *As a nonparticipant, the leader can closely monitor group members' activities.* For example, if members are talking in dyads and their discussion is not on task, the leader can intervene and help them focus by reiterating the purpose.
- *By listening and watching rather than joining in, the leader can hear what members are saying and see what they are doing.* During the processing of the exercise, a leader may even use what she heard by saying something like, "I was

listening to John and Eileen, and Eileen brought up a very important point about..." When doing this, be sure you are not revealing to the group something that the member was intending to share only with her dyad partner.

- *The leader may not want to participate because the members may focus too much on the leader's opinions or comments.* In most rounds or sentence-completion exercises, the leader usually should choose not to participate to avoid emphasis on his answers unless the answers can be very useful for the members; in other words, the leader should participate only when his participation can be of value to the members.
- By not participating, the leader can more easily get a sense of when the energy for the exercise is waning or when members have neared completion of the task. In certain kinds of exercises, the participating leader can get so involved that she loses track of time, forgets to pay attention to the energy of the group, or both.
- *A leader should not do personal work in a group he is leading.* As a rule, the leader should not participate in an exercise that could cause him to focus on his own thoughts, feelings, or "unfinished business." However, it is a good idea for him to have previously done or given considerable thought to any exercise that he uses in a group.

Leaders' participation in the activity also has its benefits.

- *Leader participation can help members get to know the leader.* Members are usually very interested in the leader's opinions, ideas, reactions, and feedback. If members view the leader as distant and nondisclosing, they may be less likely to share personally relevant material in the group.
- *The leader may wish to participate to create a certain effect.* For example, in certain kinds of groups, the leader may want to play devil's advocate to get the members to see both sides of some dilemma.
- *Participation may also be helpful in a dyad exercise if the leader sees the need to give feedback or to help a particular member.*
- *The leader may participate in an exercise when there is an odd number of participants and an even number is needed.*

Processing an Exercise

Exercises merely act as catalysts for initiating discussion by triggering thoughts and feelings. Understanding the processing of exercises is essential because the processing of the exercise is by far the most important phase of any exercise. By processing, we mean spending time discussing thoughts, feelings, and ideas that result from doing the exercise. Many books on exercises tell the potential leader what materials to use and how to conduct the exercise but spend very little time discussing how to process the exercise. In this section, we address not

only how to process an exercise but also a number of considerations regarding the processing of exercises.

Although some exercises do not need processing because they are used for warm-up or for fun, most exercises are of little value unless they are processed. For many exercises, the processing and the conducting of the exercise overlap because the discussion is part of the exercise. This is true for some feedback, sentence-completion, and experiential exercises where the leader asks processing questions while conducting the exercise. For other exercises, such as a trust walk or completing the ropes courses, the processing occurs when the exercise is completed.

The leader will want to consider several questions regarding the processing:

- What is the goal of the processing?
- How much time is needed for adequate processing?
- What processing methods should be used?
- What kinds of processing questions should be used?
- How much time should be spent discussing the actual exercise?
- Should the focus be on the entire group or on one individual?
- When should the focus be held, and when should it be shifted?
- Is the exercise present-centered or past-centered? Do I want to focus on the past or present?

Goals of Processing

There are three possible goals when processing an exercise, each having a slightly different focus.

- *To stimulate sharing and discussion about topics or issues.* This is the goal of most exercises. Sentence completions and other written exercises are used to get members talking about different subjects. Often movement, experiential, common reading, and moral dilemma exercises lead to beneficial discussions.

EXAMPLE

LEADER: As you were listening to others' responses, what was triggered for you?

MORRIE: I did not realize that others felt the same fears I did. Especially Roger, you and I seem so similar. I have all kinds of thoughts going through my head.

LEADER: We'll come back to you in a minute. Anyone else want to share his or her reactions?

ROGER: I do have all kinds of fears. I've never talked about them before this group.

- *To stimulate members to delve deeper into thoughts and feelings.* Leaders often use fantasy exercises, certain common readings, creative exercises, and many other kinds of exercises to get members in touch with their feelings. The goal is to help members share at a deep, personal level.

EXAMPLE

LEADER: What did this reading get you to think about regarding how you are living? Are you living life as if it is a dress rehearsal?

BRENDA: Sure made me stop and think. I know I am not happy in my relationship and haven't been for months. Certain phrases really hit home for me.

FRANK: Many phrases hit me. I am just going through the motions of living and not working hard on my marriage. Like it says, life is not a dress rehearsal!

- *To stimulate sharing and discussion related to the group dynamics and group process.* For example, a trust walk exercise can lead to a discussion about trust and then specifically about trust within the group. An exercise where members rate how they feel about the group will usually lead to a discussion about the group dynamics and group process. Group-decision exercises and experiential exercises often lead to processing that focuses on what is happening within the group.

EXAMPLE

LEADER: I want you to think about the meaning of this exercise. All of you sculpted how you felt about this group and not one person put themselves as open or toward the center of the group. What do you think this means?

ALEXIS: We don't trust each other or something. I know I worry about being judged.

CARLETTA: I want this to be a good experience. The last group I was in was great. No one shares much here. I would, but no one else seems to want to.

NINA: *(To the leader)* Do you think something is wrong with the group?

LEADER: Let me say it this way—so much more could happen in the group.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Processing an Exercise

Now go back to videos 10.1, 10.2, 10.3, and 10.4 and pay particular attention to how the leader processes the exercise to get members to go deeper into themselves.

Time Needed for Adequate Processing

A leader should always make sure there is enough time to process the exercise to the depth desired. Many exercises are designed to take members to a very deep, personal level. Unfortunately, a number of group leaders fail to allow enough time for processing. They either begin the exercise when there is not adequate time to discuss members' reactions or they move on to another activity too soon. Both of these mistakes can lead to frustration, confusion, and a shallow, meaningless experience.

EXAMPLES

Ineffective Processing

LEADER: I want you to think of an animal that you would like to be if you could be any animal in the world. What would it be? *(Pause)* Who wants to go first?

FRANK: A cat.

DANNIE: A tiger.

MEL: A big black bear.

SHARON: A bird.

LEADER: Any comments?

SHARON: Dave reminds me of an alligator.

DANNIE: I agree, he does. He sort of sits and waits.

LEADER: Any other comments? *(Pause)* Now I'd like you to think of where you would like to live if you could live anywhere you wanted.

In this example, the leader does not spend time discussing the members' choices before going on to a second exercise. Therefore, very little, if anything, is gained from the exercise. The skilled leader has a purpose for doing the animal fantasy exercise. The leader would spend a few minutes having members share why they chose their particular animal and how that may relate to their own lives. This exercise can lead to discussion that can last an entire session if the leader understands its purpose.

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Effective Processing—allowing enough time for deeper exploration

LEADER: I want you to think of an animal that you would like to be if you could be any animal in the world. What would it be and why? *(Pause)* Who wants to go first?

FRANK: A cat.

LEADER: Why?

FRANK: They are independent, take care of themselves, but they are also taken care of by their owner.

DANNIE: A tiger because they are feared, fast, and pretty.

SHARON: A bird because they are free, can soar, and are not confined.

LEADER: How does the animal you pick either remind you of yourself or get you in touch with something you desire?

SHARON: I don't feel free right now in my life, and I feel very confined by my boyfriend.

LEADER: We'll come back to you. Let me hear others' insights.

FRANK: Wow! I thought this was sort of dumb at first, but I'm blown away. I really want someone to take care of me and my girlfriend expects me to take complete care of her. No wonder I resent her! I do need to talk about this some more.

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Another mistake leaders make regarding time is letting the exercise take up too much time, leaving only a few minutes for processing. For example, the elementary school counselor could mistakenly give members 15 minutes to draw their families and then have only 5–7 minutes to talk about the drawings. *In most cases, the majority of time allotted to an exercise should be for processing the exercise and not for conducting it.*

Ways of Processing

When an exercise has been conducted and completed, it can be processed in several ways:

- Rounds
- Dyads or triads
- Writing
- In the entire group
- In any combination of the preceding four ways

The round is a good way to start the processing because it gives the leader a chance to hear briefly every member's reaction. The leader can say something like, "In a sentence or two, what stood out to you about the exercise?" or

"Let's go around the group and hear from each of you as to what you thought of the reading."

A leader may want to use dyads or triads when there seems to be a lot of energy and members can benefit from sharing their thoughts and feelings. Using dyads or triads gives everyone a chance to talk. Writing can be used after exercises where members have many thoughts and feelings they might want to express but not share with anyone else. Exercises that are very thought-provoking and emotional, such as family sculpture or certain fantasy exercises, may lend themselves to this kind of processing.

Even if the first three ways are used, the majority of the processing will occur among the entire group. The first three ways listed often serve as a way to start the processing. Once the group is warmed up, the leader can use questions to stimulate the discussion, such as, "Does anyone want to share thoughts or feelings?" or "What was triggered for you?" or "Let's talk about your reactions." The leader can also use these questions at the beginning of the processing if she feels that no warm-up is necessary.

■ EXAMPLES

Members have just completed an exercise where they drew egograms (a transactional analysis diagram) of themselves at home, at work, and with their family of origin.

LEADER: This activity usually stirs up a lot of thoughts and feelings. First, I am going to get you to pair up and share your egograms and any thoughts that you have. Let's see, the two of you pair up, and the two of you, and the two of you... *(Allows 5 minutes for sharing)* Let's come back to the large group. What have you learned from doing this exercise? Do you see some changes that you want to make?

In this example, the leader uses dyads and then the whole group for processing the exercise. In the next example, the leader uses a round and then opens the discussion to the entire group with questions that will deepen the focus.

■ ■ ■

LEADER: *(After viewing a 20-minute movie)* Let's do a quick round on your reactions to the movie on a 1–10 scale, with 10 being *has you really thinking* and 1 being *the movie had no impact.* Who wants to start?

RAMOS: 10.

CLYDE: 8.

MARLENE: 9.

PAULETTE: 8.

TRAY: 8.

LEADER: So everyone is really thinking. We should be able to have a very interesting session. What hit you? What are you thinking about?

■ ■ ■

LEADER: *(After conducting an exercise where everyone explores his or her own personal space)* What did you experience in doing this exercise?

MONICA: I felt comfortable until you asked me to go outside of my space. That did not feel good. I worried about invading others.

ANNETTE: Me too. I worried about touching someone.

ANITA: I didn't mind and I kind of liked it. I felt sort of confined in my space.

LEADER: That's interesting and something we can explore. Some of you felt comfortable outside of your space and others did not. Let's talk about how your experience just now relates to your life and not just to the exercise.

■ ■ ■

Kinds of Processing Questions

The skilled leader will always consider the kinds of processing questions to ask, because her questions direct the focus of the processing (Kees & Jacobs, 1990). The questions can cause members to focus on the exercise, the group, issues or topics, or on individuals. Questions such as "What happened?" "What did you draw?" and "What part of the reading stood out?" are the kinds of questions that get the members to talk about the exercise. These questions are often used at the beginning of the processing phase, but some leaders make the mistake of using only these questions, which can lead to a superficial group.

If the leader wants the members to go deeper, she should also use other kinds of questions, such as the following:

- What insights did you get from doing this?
- What feelings were stirred up for you?
- How can you use this exercise to help you in your life?

Leaders will always want to make sure that their questions are congruent with the goal of the exercise. The biggest mistake leaders make is asking questions that do not foster any in-depth exploration—questions that generate discussion at the 10 or 9 level instead of at the deeper 8, 7, or 6 levels. The processing questions should help funnel the group to a deeper level. Glass and Benshoff (1999) discuss a model for processing certain kinds of exercises. Their article emphasizes the importance of asking the right questions at the different stages of processing. In the appendix to their article, they list specific questions for the nine different stages they outline as important in processing an exercise.

Time Spent Discussing the Actual Exercise

Often, the leader has to decide how long to discuss the actual exercise. For instance, if the group has just engaged in a fantasy exercise, the leader would want to let members tell their fantasy, but the main purpose of processing is to get them to talk about what feelings they encounter. The same is true of a movement exercise where people struggled to reach their goals. The processing is initially on what it felt like when they had to struggle, but the leader would want to rather quickly center the discussion on the struggles they are having in their lives, not the struggle in the exercise. It is very easy to allow members to share at a superficial level about the exercise itself and thus not maximize the benefit of the exercise. Many leaders make the mistake of having members merely talk about the exercise and do not try to take the discussion to a deeper, more meaningful level. Leaders can eliminate this mistake by asking good, thought-provoking questions that tap into the emotions and feelings of the members.

EXAMPLES

The leader has just completed a movement exercise where the members were told to form a circle and hold hands. Then the leader asked members to silently pick a spot in the room toward which they were to try to pull the rest of the group. The purpose of this exercise is to see how determined and persistent members are and to see how they attempt to get what they want.

LEADER: What was that like? What happened?

JOSÉ: Boy, that was tough. I really got into that exercise. Sandy, you should have seen the look on your face as you tried to pull away from the group!

SANDY: Yeah, I was surprised at how strong you were, José. All I could think to do was to free myself from your grip.

DONALD: I had no idea that you girls could pull as strongly as you did....

It is evident here that the discussion is conversational. No real learning is taking place, because the members are merely discussing their actions during the exercise itself. This is fine for the first couple of minutes, but to effectively process the exercise so that the members learn from it and apply this learning to their lives, the leader needs to ask some additional questions such as, "Think for just a moment about what this exercise meant to you. What did you learn that you can apply to your current life situations?" The leader could also say, "Did this exercise have any meaning for you in terms of your lives outside this group?" Group discussion following such leader prompts might sound something like the following:

ANGIE: Yes, the thing that stood out to me about this exercise is that I tend to fear competition. I've always shunned opportunities to compete and,

as a result, I think I've been missing out on some potentially rewarding experiences.

DONALD: That's interesting, Angie. I feel almost the opposite, in that I always compete and have a difficult time just enjoying life without always comparing myself to others. I often come up short when I play the comparing game.

In this dialogue, the group members are applying their reactions to their lives, and the exercise acts to trigger thoughts. Keep in mind that the exercise usually only stimulates members' reactions. It is the leader's guiding statements that often cause members to personalize the experience.

■ ■ ■

This group has just completed a fantasy exercise that involved having the members visualize themselves on a journey to see an old wise person.

Ineffective Processing

LEADER: What was it like seeing the wise man?

JERRY: My wise man had a long, gray beard.

TED: Mine was dressed in a long, white robe and carried a cane.

CRISTINA: When we met each other, I gave him a hug.

JANET: "He" was a "she" and she never said a word to me, but I know that she was glad to see me because she smiled.

LEADER: What else happened when you saw the wise man or woman?

JOEY: I was frightened. I thought he had too much on his mind to see me.

TAMMY: It felt good. He was glad to see me and I wanted to stay longer.

LEADER: Did the wise man or woman give any of you an answer to your question?

TED: Yes.

JANET: She just smiled when I asked her my question.

LEADER: What about when you left? How did you feel?

The discussion could continue like this for the entire session, with members recounting what they thought and imagined during the exercise. The discussion would remain on a surface level, with no significant learning taking place. The members are not applying the exercise to their lives.

■ ■ ■

Effective Processing

LEADER: Did any of the thoughts, feelings, and images you had as you went to see the wise person relate, in any way, to your own personal life?

Cristina: It did for me. Seeing the wise man was just like going to see my grandfather. I'm always glad to see him and we always hug.

Joey: I was really scared as I walked up that mountain, I was afraid that he wouldn't be glad to see me or wouldn't have time for me. I sometimes feel that way when I'm at home. I have four brothers and sisters, and sometimes I feel like Mom and Dad don't have time for me.

Leader: Maybe that's something we can talk about in a minute. It seems important.

Ted: It felt like the wise man was telling me not to worry about school and home so much. I worry a lot about those things sometimes, and it makes me sad.

Leader: I never thought of you as worrying about your home life. Would you like to talk about that?

Ted: Yes, I think I would.

Leader: Okay, we'll do that sometime before the session is over. I want to get a few more comments about the experience of seeing the wise person. Janet?

Janet: When I asked the wise woman my question, she just smiled. Then I realized that I have the answer inside me, and I don't always have to rely on other people to make decisions for me.

Leader: Any significance or importance that you changed the person to be a woman?

In this processing, the members are relating in a personal manner. The exercise opens avenues for discussion and allows members to share their thoughts and feelings as well as to hear the reactions of others. Because processing the exercise has caused members to share personal information, several concerns have emerged. The leader may now choose to focus more intensely on Ted's or Joey's concerns.

■ ■ ■

Focusing on One Member or on the Entire Group

When processing exercises for personal growth, support, and therapy groups, the leader sometimes has to decide whether to focus on one person or on the group. *It is usually best at the beginning of the processing phase to hear from all the members who feel like sharing in order to get a sense of what is going on with the members.* This can be done by using rounds or by just asking for some brief comments about members'

reactions to an exercise. If there are members who would like to work on something, the leader has to decide whether focusing on one person is better than continuing the discussion with the entire group. The last scenario is a good example of the leader deciding whether to go with a group discussion or an individual focus on either Ted or Joey.

It is difficult to give specific guidelines about when the leader should focus on individuals. In a growth group, you may not want to hold the focus too long on one individual. If the group is a support or therapy group, it is often very beneficial to let the focus be on one person for 10 to 20 minutes, especially if that person is willing to work at a deep personal level (6 or below on the depth chart).

EXAMPLES

In this example, the leader focuses on one person for a while.

LEADER: As you were listening to others' responses, what got triggered for you?

MORRIE: I did not realize that others felt the same fears I did. Especially Roger, you and I seem so similar. I have all kinds of thoughts going through my head.

LEADER: We'll come back to you in a minute. Anyone else want to share his or her reactions?

OTHERS: ...

LEADER: Morrie, do you want to work on getting rid of those fears?

MORRIE: Most definitely. My fears keep me from doing all kinds of things. Probably my biggest one is ...

* * *

Using the same example, the leader chooses to focus on a topic rather than one person.

LEADER: Let's take the topic of fears. How does fear affect your life?

MORRIE: My fears keep me from doing all kinds of things. Probably my biggest one is fear of mistakes at work. Just the other day, I had a situation that ...

LEADER: *(With a caring voice)* Morrie, let me interrupt you. I'd like us first to discuss in general our fears and how they affect us, and then we'll go into specific situations that have occurred recently. Anyone else want to comment about their fears?

ROGER: My fear is more related to women and what they will think. I don't worry about men's approval.

STEPHANIE: That's so interesting. I don't think my fears have to do with others but more myself. I fear failing at new things so I don't try many new things.

■ ■ ■

Holding and Shifting the Focus

An error commonly made by inexperienced group leaders when processing an exercise is to focus the group for too long on the first person who talks. It is usually best for the leader to give all or most of the members a chance to talk before holding the focus on any one person or issue. Exercises should create energy and interest among all the members. Focusing prematurely on one member may result in losing the interest and attention of others who have not had a chance to react to the exercise. Also, be aware that the first person who speaks may be speaking out of anxiety, a need for attention, or a desire to please the leader. This member's response may therefore be a function of those needs rather than a reflection of genuine feelings about the issue.

■ EXAMPLES

Ineffective Processing

LEADER: *(Following a sentence-completion exercise)* Who would like to share an answer with the group?

TOD: *(Appearing eager to respond)* I would. On that question concerning my thoughts on divorce, I thought about what different reactions people have. My one uncle was depressed for months and hardly left his house except to go to work. My other uncle, however, seemed to be happier as a result and went on about his life as though nothing had happened. What do you suppose was the difference?

LEADER: I don't know. What do you think the difference could have been?

TOD: *(In a storytelling voice)* Well, one difference could have been the length of time that they were married or the fact that one uncle had been divorced once before. He told me ...

In this example, Tod is the first to speak, and his response is not relevant to the group. His voice indicates he is not speaking introspectively but rather with a storytelling intent. The leader makes an error in continuing to focus

on him instead of tapping into the energy generated from completing the sentences.

■ ■ ■

Effective Processing

LEADER: Who would like to share an answer with the group?

TOD: *(Appearing eager to respond)* I would. On that question concerning my thoughts on divorce, I thought about what different reactions people have. My one uncle was depressed for months and hardly left his house except to go to work. My other uncle, however, seemed to be happier as a result and went on about his life as though nothing had happened. What do you suppose was the difference?

LEADER: I'm not too sure in their particular cases, Tod. If you are interested in exploring this, you and I can do it after the group adjourns. Right now, however, I would like others to share their specific answers with the group.

TIM: For number 1, I said divorce does not always mean failure.

LEADER: What did others answer for number 1?

DORIS: *(Crying)* I do feel like a failure. I never wanted to put my kids through a divorce and a broken home. *(Sobbing)* I just don't know why this had to happen and what I did wrong.

LEADER: Doris, I know you blame yourself, but from what you have told us, your husband had a serious drug problem. I want us to focus on Doris, but I do want all of you to think about this failure issue. *(With a kind voice)* Doris, I want you to look at us and tell us truthfully what you think you could have done to save this marriage, given your husband's drug problem.

In this example, the leader chooses not to focus on Tod, even though there seems to be some energy. Many novice leaders are so relieved that someone is speaking that they will focus on the first person to speak rather than give others a chance to comment briefly. Also, the leader realizes that it would be a mistake to hold the focus on Tod, because the purpose of the exercise is to get members talking more personally about divorce. By shifting the focus from Tod, the leader allows Doris to share her deep-seated feelings.

■ ■ ■

Present-Centered or Past-Centered Exercises

Although most exercises focus on the present, many are designed to get members to reflect on their pasts. Members may be asked to draw the houses they lived in

when they were young or to describe how they felt when they were 10 years old. A potentially powerful exercise that focuses on the past is to have members bring in pictures from childhood.

There is no right or wrong about where exercises should focus. We do feel that, in most cases, focusing in the present about the past is usually more productive than just focusing on the past. The reason for this is that group members cannot change their past, but they can change how they are affected by it. It is good to focus on the past to get at various hidden and possibly painful issues, but then it is usually important to bring the discussion to the present. The following questions can help to do this:

- How do you think your past affects you today?
- What can you learn from looking at those past relationships?
- It is important to look at how our past experiences affect us today. What did you learn?
- Does this stir up some unfinished business that you may want to work on?
- What feelings from your childhood do you need to sort out?

The leader should usually be considering how to help members in the present even when conducting a past-centered exercise. We stress this point about past-centered exercises because we have seen too many group leaders focus on the past and not have members consider what they need to do in the present to change their feelings or thoughts. This gets members to reflect or tell old childhood stories but doesn't help members address any issues that are currently bothering them about their past.

EXAMPLES

Ineffective Processing

LEADER: Now that you have drawn the house you grew up in, what did that bring up for you?

KIM: It made me think about all the times my dad got drunk, and yelled and screamed at me for no reason.

CINDI: I felt sad that my parents sold that house two years ago. I loved that house and had such good memories. I liked the neighborhood—lots of friends to play with.

SONNY: I always wanted a bigger house. Four of us had to sleep in one room. I still resent it! I do have some good memories of the times my grandpa visited. He was a great guy—he loved music so he always had us playing music.

LEADER: What kind of music did you play?

SONNY: All kinds. One time he ...

■ ■ ■

Effective Processing

LEADER: Now that you have drawn the house you grew up in, what did that bring up for you?

KIM: It made me think about all the times my dad got drunk and yelled and screamed at me for no reason.

CINDI: I felt sad that my parents sold that house two years ago. I loved that house and had such good memories. I liked the neighborhood—lots of friends to play with.

SONNY: I always wanted a bigger house. Four of us had to sleep in one room. I still resent it! I do have some good memories of the times my grandpa visited. He was a great guy—he loved music so he always had us playing music.

LEADER: Let me get you to come to the present and think about what you just said or felt, and let's talk about any feelings you may have as a result of your childhood.

KIM: Like what?

LEADER: For instance, Kim, what effect does your dad's screaming then have on you now? Or with Cindi—any feelings about your parents selling the house?

CINDI: You know, I realize that I am very mad at them. I think that I didn't have a good Christmas because I am still mad at them.

LEADER: Let's hear from others and then we'll come back to you and talk some more about that *(Cindi nods).*

KIM: I'll tell you what his screaming did—it causes me to cringe when anyone even raises his or her voice at me. I know my husband sometimes gets loud and I freak out. We have actually fought about this on numerous occasions.

■ ■ ■

Concluding Comments

This concludes our discussion of exercises. We hope this chapter combined with Chapter 10, "Exercises," gives you a better understanding of the kinds of exercises, when to use them, how to introduce them, and how to conduct and process them. Throughout this chapter, we have pointed out a number of

common mistakes made by leaders when using exercises. The following is a review of some of the main points to consider when using an exercise in your group:

- Choose the kind of exercise that is best for what you are trying to accomplish.
- Make sure the exercise is relevant to members' needs and the group's purpose.
- Make sure directions are clearly stated.
- Try to clear up any confusion before the exercise actually begins. Keep directions short and simple.
- Make sure all necessary materials are in members' hands before introducing the exercise.
- Place handouts or sentence completions facedown before starting, to avoid distraction.
- Generally, have members stand up and get situated before giving directions for movement exercises.
- Give directions that include enough information for completing the exercise successfully.
- Allow members to not participate.
- Explain the purpose of an exercise before beginning it.
- Announce how long the exercise will last.
- Remember that exercises are means, not ends. Learning comes through processing.
- Open processing discussions with thought-provoking, open-ended questions. When processing an exercise, make it relevant to group members' lives. Do not use exercises one after another without processing sufficiently in between.

ACTIVITIES

1. Think of three exercises that you have never conducted before. Write down how you would introduce, conduct, and process the exercises.
2. Think of groups or classes where exercises were used to facilitate discussion. Think about the leader's effectiveness at introducing, conducting, and processing the exercises. This activity is especially helpful when you pick leaders who did not do a good job in introducing, conducting, and processing.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. View video 5.3 and watch how the leader introduced, conducted, and processed the rounds and sentence completion exercises.
2. View video 7.1 and watch how the leader introduced, conducted, and processed the exercise on anger using fuses.
3. View video 8.7 and watch how the leader introduced, conducted, and processed the exercise using movement to get quiet members talking. Why was this movement exercise valuable given that the leader had three quiet, hesitant members?
4. View video 14.3 and watch how the leader introduced, conducted, and processed the simple round exercise regarding unfinished business?
   a. What skills did the leader use during the processing phase?
   b. What did the leader do to get members to go deeper?